A guide for engineers, architects, and product leaders

Prompt, skill, or agent?

Choose the right level of AI capability for the work you need done.

PROMPT

Tell it what you want.

SKILL

Give it a reusable procedure.

AGENT

Let it choose and execute the next step.

Three different jobs

PROMPT

A task-specific instruction

Use when the request is clear and bounded.

Example: Explain the approval paths in this BPMN file.

SKILL

A reusable way of working

Use when the same procedure and checks repeat.

Example: Edit Flowable nodes, preserve BPMNDI, and validate.

AGENT

A system that decides and acts

Use when later steps depend on earlier results.

Example: Inspect, edit, validate, and correct until done.

One task. Three layers.

They complement each other; they are not competing options.

YOUR PROMPT

Add an approval task before account creation.

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AGENT RUNTIME

Inspects the file, chooses actions, calls tools, and checks the results.

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REUSABLE SKILL

Provides Flowable editing rules, reference material, and validation scripts.

Tools do the actual work: read files, edit BPMN, run validation, or call APIs. The agent can revisit the skill as needed.

Example: edit a workflow

Goal: add approval before a virtual account is created.

1 Request the change

Prompt: state the desired behavior and constraints.

2 Use the editing procedure

Skill: explain node wiring, IDs, BPMNDI, and checks.

3 Run the feedback loop

Agent: inspect > edit > validate > correct if needed.

Completion criteria

The approval path is correct, validation passes, and the diagram remains viewable.

Use a fixed workflow when every step is already known. Add agent decisions only where adaptation is useful.

What should you build?

A A clear, one-time request?

Start with a prompt. Example: summarize one policy.

B A repeated procedure?

Package a skill. Example: a standard code review.

C Uncertain steps with feedback?

Use an agent. Example: investigate a failed workflow.

D Fixed rules or exact calculations?

Use deterministic code or a defined workflow.

Complexity is a cost. More autonomy adds evaluation, permission, latency, and operating-cost decisions.